

Imagine, all the coders

Michael Eisner, the celebrated CEO of Walt Disney Inc, may be in trouble these days with his shareholders, but his record is impeccable. He made his company from a faltering legend, to a dominating entertainment giant, more than quadrupled revenues and profits, and brought the magic back in the Disney name.

might be bored of seeing the same faces, so we roped in Jyotsna and Saailesh.

Saailesh: I was interested the moment I heard Brazil!

■ What is Gurukul all about?

Jyotsna: Gurukul is a sort of virtual university—an interface between students, teachers, industry and universities. It tries to simplify the lives of students.

Tejas: You could access your university sitting in a cyber café, talk to professors and students, and find mentors. It's the right place to clear doubts.

■ What differentiates Gurukul from other e-learning software?

Jyotsna: Gurukul has some good features; search, for instance. The Idea Search prompts a user to look for more than the usual. For instance, a student interested in a diode might be interested in transmitters, too. It's smart enough to pick up on behaviour, and provide results accordingly... it's a wrapper around the sort of search technology that Google uses.

Tejas: Other features include workspaces for students and tutors. The spaces allow students to work on their projects, chat for reference, and also seek guidance from lecturers or the industry. Another feature is mentoring. A student can approach any industry professional or an academic who could be the mentor.

Abhijeet: The application will bridge the gap between what is taught in institutions and what the real industry is all about.

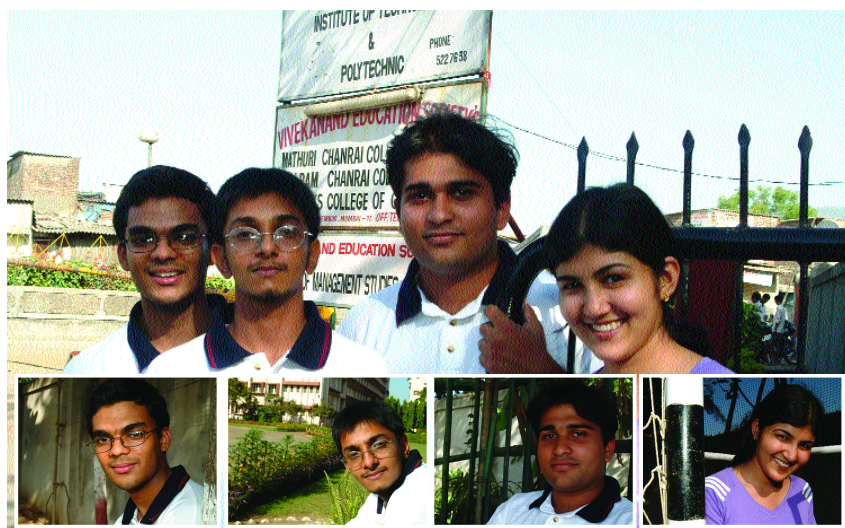
Let's say you would like to have access to certain hardware, such as the upcoming (Intel) Tejas architecture. With the terminal services feature built into Gurukul, students can log into the remote machine and access it.

Saailesh: There is also localisation in addition to its bilingual nature. Since equal importance is given to both Hindi and English, it has the potential of mass reach.

Gurukul will allow students to refer to e-books within the portal. Our application supports the tablet interface too.

■ E-books? Won't that create copyright issues?

Tejas: Microsoft is working on Digital Rights Management (DRM) controls for distribution of e-books. The (legally available) e-books that we have within Gurukul, allow the user to highlight, add comments, and annotate all over. There are copies of the textbooks always available for reference.



The Geek4: (left to right) Tejas Shah, Saailesh Ganesh, Abhijeet Akhawe and Jyotsna Rathore, when we caught up with them on their college campus in April 2004

“ The application will bridge the gap between what is taught in institutions and what the real industry is all about ”

One of his revolutionary moves was, however, not related to his money-making ability. It was coining a different name for the immensely-talented people at Disney—Imagineers.

It will not be incorrect to call Mumbai-based Vivekananda Education Society's Institute of Technology-trained Tejas Shah, Jyotsna Rathore, Saailesh Ganesh and Abhijeet Akhawe imagineers. They are the only four to represent India at the world finals of the Microsoft Imagine Cup this July in São Paulo, Brazil—an annual competition where college students from all over the world display their .NET applications to vie for the top prize—\$ 25,000 (Rs 11,25,000).

For the national finals in Bangalore last month, the quartet came up with Gurukul, an e-learning application that aims to “simplify lives of students”.

Just a couple of months before they embark on a tour that could make their career, Digit met up with the Geek4 at the holiest of all college environments—the canteen. Excerpts from a free-wheeling interview:

■ So how did Geek4 form?

Tejas: Abhijeet and I had participated in last year's Imagine Cup; we were the runners up in Barcelona, Spain. (Smiles) We thought people